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ADD-ONS FOR OLDER MODEL MAY SUIT FAMILY'S NEEDS, TOO

Good student computer can be as low as \$500

Experts advise starting simple with youngsters, upgrading as kids grow

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North Carolina's first tax-free weekend (and South Carolina's third) couldn't come at a better time for computer-hunting families: Prices have never been lower, experts say.

OK, the same could have been said for last holiday season ... and last back-to-school season ... and the holiday season before that.

It's a bit of a dilemma in the ever-cheaper computer market.

"No matter when you buy," said Harry McCracken, editor of PC World magazine, "you'll find something cooler for less money in two weeks."

That said, if you need a computer so the kids can ace tests, get it now - with no regrets.

Here's shopping advice from McCracken and Paul Kastner, chief research officer with Aberdeen Group, a Boston technology marketing analysis firm:

■ **New computers:** First-time computer shoppers probably feel a bit like Goldilocks - you want to find a system that's just right. You don't want one so complicated that you think you need a Ph.D. to use it, or one so wimpy it's unable to run your favorite programs.

Consider the age of the student. For elementary school, the family's 4-year-old computer will do, while high-schoolers might need a new PC for their entertainment demands, Kastner said.

Most families should be happy with a \$900 desktop system with 128 megabytes of memory and a Celeron processor, McCracken said. That's good enough for word

processing and Web surfing. And some systems include printers.

Kastner said parents should consider buying a low-end computer with few gadgets - those costing as little as \$500. They might have smaller hard drives and lack printers, but you can add goodies later.

McCracken offered warnings: Avoid buying more PC than you need, and watch out for deals that offer a free PC, which usually require commitment to an Internet provider that's not the cheapest.

■ **Upgrading:** What's wrong with that desktop you've used for years? Probably nothing, and for a little less dough you can upgrade your computer.

Memory is cheap, and a processor upgrade starts at about \$150, McCracken said. Parents could also replace a CD player with a CD-RW drive so junior can back up files and burn music for that paper on "The role of pop

stars in national security."

(A word of caution on adding DVDs: Because of different standards, not all DVD drives are compatible with all computers, McCracken said. Check the computer manufacturer's Web site to see which drives are compatible.)

If you find yourself spending \$400 or more for upgrades, it might be worth buying the new system, McCracken said.

■ **Laptops:** Think of them as computers to go. They also take up less space in your computer station. And if you have college-bound offspring, they will likely need one to play ga ... take notes in class. Understand that notebooks offer less bang for the buck. You can get a good laptop for about \$1,000, but a \$1,300 laptop is about the equivalent of a \$900 desktop, McCracken said. Just be sure to get a lock.

■ **Apple Computers:** Though Apples make up a small part of the

personal computing market, the company makes some great easy-to-use desktops (\$750 and up) and laptops (\$1,200 and up).

■ **Software:** An intangible that might be the decision-maker. Some systems will come with Microsoft Office, while others will have the less-powerful Microsoft Works. Look at what free software is included, such as educational programs. Be sure to buy anti-virus software and a firewall to repel hackers.

■ **Furniture:** The tower, monitor, keyboard, mouse and printer need space. You might want a computer desk, Kastner said, which costs anywhere from \$50 to more than \$1,000.

More Buying Tips

■ Make sure the computer package includes a monitor.
■ Learn about the latest deals at www.aberdeen.com.

■ Add \$100 to your budget for various knick-knacks, including a surge protector and printer supplies.

(printers and supplies are also sales-tax free).

■ Warranty periods vary. Some are for a year, others up to three years.

■ Consider adding a wireless network if your home has multiple computers. That will allow your family to share a printer and a Web connection, a money-saver.

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